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Can A Judge Prevent A Child From Attending Church?

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BY PNW STAFF JUNE 10, 2026

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What happens when a government court decides that a child can no longer attend her church?

That question is now at the center of one of the most extraordinary religious liberty cases unfolding in America.

For nearly 18 months, a 13-year-old Maine girl has been prohibited from attending Calvary Chapel in Portland, Maine--the church she regularly attended with her mother and where many of her closest friends worshipped. The ruling effectively severed her from her church community, youth activities, Bible studies, Christian fellowship, holiday celebrations, and many of the relationships that had become central to her spiritual life.

The case involves Ava Bickford and her mother, Emily Bickford, who have spent the past year and a half fighting a court order that many religious liberty advocates believe strikes at the heart of the First Amendment.

The restrictions were imposed in late 2024 during a custody dispute between Ava's parents and remain in place while Maine's Supreme Judicial Court considers an appeal that could have ramifications far beyond a single family.

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For many Christians, the case raises a troubling question: If a court can prevent a child from attending a Bible-believing church because of concerns about the church's teachings, where does that authority end?

This is not a case involving abuse, neglect, criminal activity, or physical danger.

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Her father objected, arguing that teachings she was hearing at church were contributing to anxiety and emotional stress. Court filings referenced concerns that Ava had become worried about spiritual matters, including discussions surrounding salvation and the return of Christ.

To support those concerns, the court relied heavily on testimony from a sociologist presented as a "cult expert," who characterized Calvary Chapel as exhibiting cult-like characteristics.

Among the beliefs cited were doctrines familiar to virtually every Christian denomination: belief in heaven and hell, angels and demons, salvation through Jesus Christ, and pastors who teach Scripture verse-by-verse and chapter-by-chapter.

That alone should give Americans pause.

If belief in heaven and hell is evidence of a dangerous religious environment, then much of historic Christianity suddenly finds itself under suspicion.

If teaching the Bible systematically becomes a warning sign, then countless evangelical, Baptist, Pentecostal, Lutheran, Presbyterian, Catholic, and Orthodox congregations could theoretically face similar accusations.



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That concern is precisely why Liberty Counsel, a national religious liberty legal organization, became involved in the case.

The organization rarely enters ordinary custody disputes. Attorneys say they viewed this case differently because it raised profound constitutional questions regarding parental rights and religious freedom.

The court ultimately granted Ava's father final authority over her religious upbringing and prohibited her attendance at Calvary Chapel.

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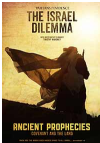
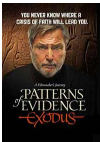
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It may help determine whether America's courts continue to protect the free exercise of religion--or whether judges increasingly assume the authority to decide when a child's exposure to biblical Christianity has gone too far.

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